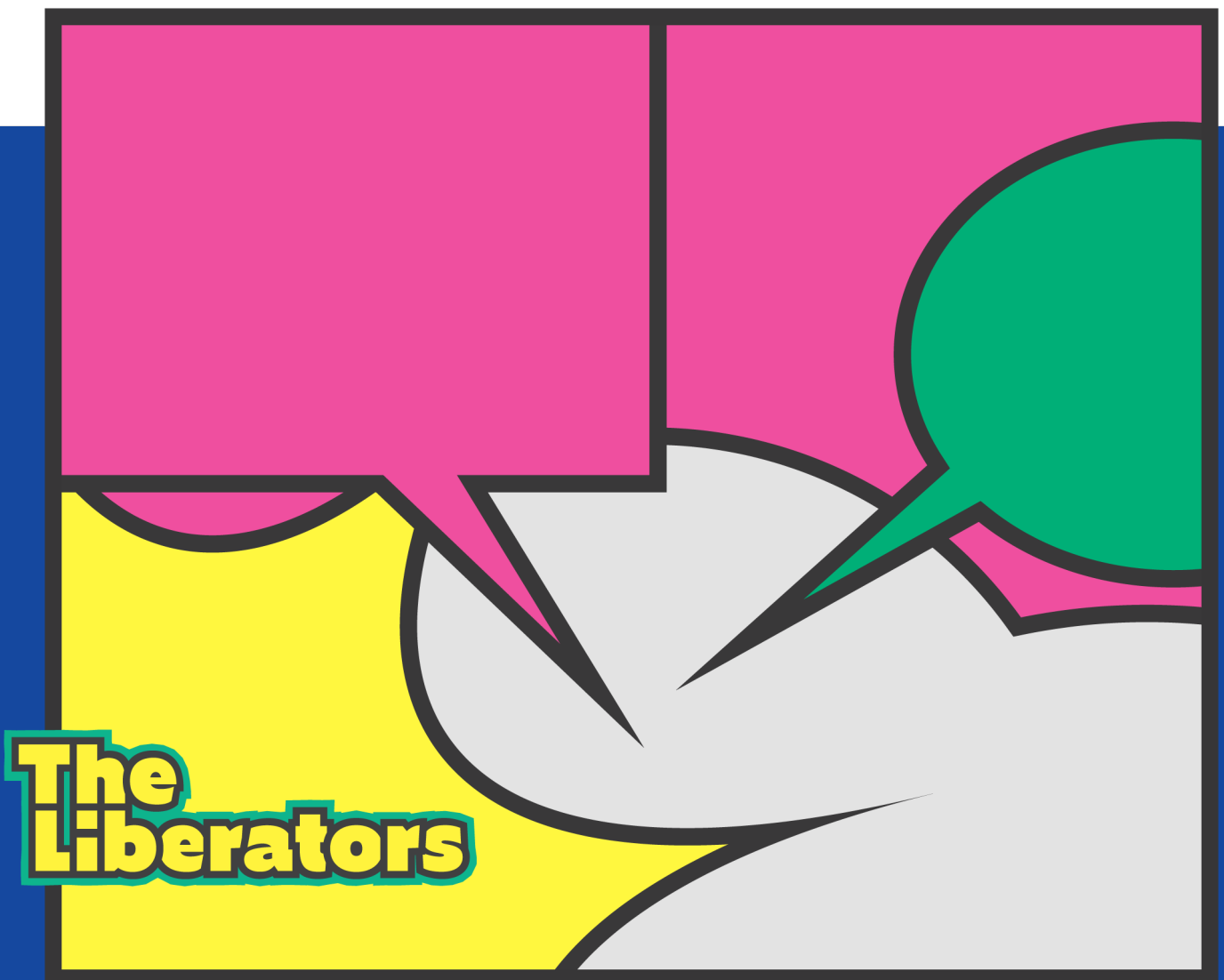


Ecocycle Planning For Scrum Teams

Use this virtual exercise to periodically diagnose how capable your team is in working empirically, and work together to identify improvements



Hey There, Scrum Practitioner!

How is your Scrum Team investing in its ability to work empirically? To work closely with stakeholders? To release faster? To increase the autonomy of the team and reduce their dependency on others? And to persistently find the time to improve in all these areas?

In our book [The Zombie Scrum Survival Guide](#) we identify four areas that matter most to Professional Scrum:

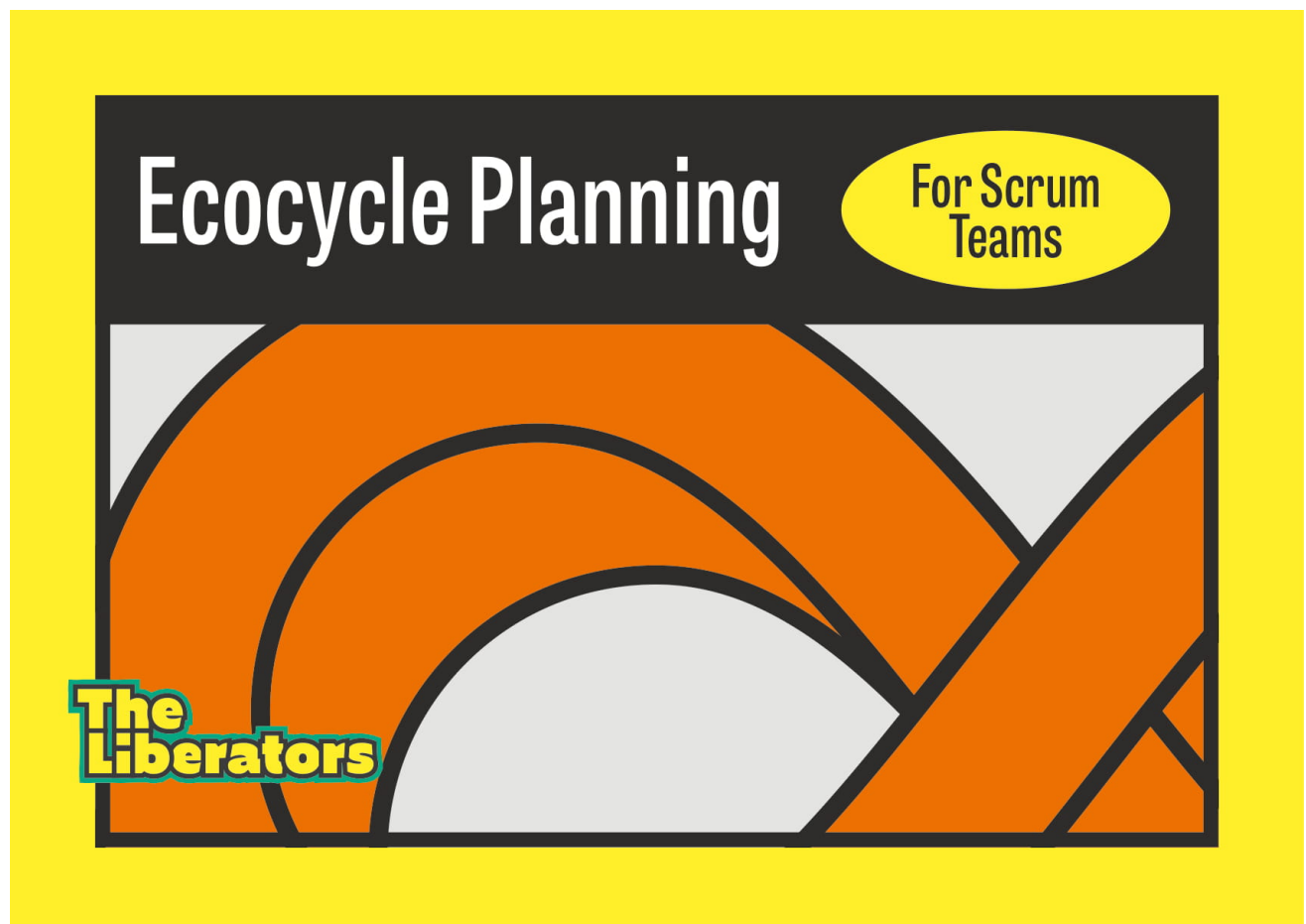
- Build What Stakeholders Need;
- Ship It Fast;
- Improve Continuously;
- Self-organize Around Impediments;

How is your team investing in the activities that make this possible? We created this exercise to help your team create transparency around how they are investing their time, and where improvements can be made.

The exercise is built on the powerful Liberating Structure [Ecocycle Planning](#). With this structure, you engage everyone in and around your team to create transparency around the activities that prevent Zombie Scrum. For example: "We celebrate our successes, both large and small", "We decide what is on the Product Backlog and in what order, without requiring approval from people outside the team" and "We improve our tools and technologies to make it easier to ship faster and safer".

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Flow

Step 1: Opening

 5 min

Step 2: Diagnose The Status Quo

  40 min

Step 3: Inspect Together

  30 min

Step 4: Identify Improvements

  30 min

Step 5: Personal Next Steps

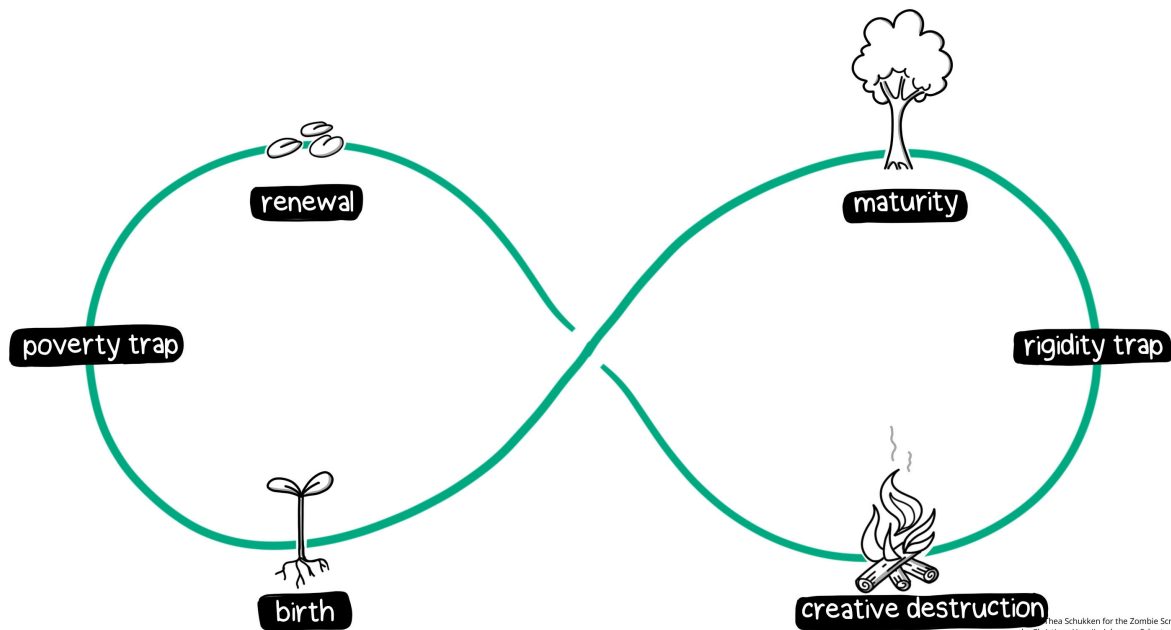
  10 min

Total duration

 115 min



A Metaphore From Nature




The Scrum Survival Guide
by Christian Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Ecocycle Planning is part of the repertoire of Liberating Structures. Its purpose is to analyze the full portfolio of activities and identify obstacles and opportunities for progress in a markedly non-linear way. That makes it an excellent way to periodically reflect on your work together and to decide what to focus on next. It is based on the life cycle in nature.

The activities of your Scrum Team can be plotted on an Ecocycle as follows:

- **Renewal** represents all the activities that you think would be useful to you as a team, but that you are not doing at the moment.
- **Birth** represents the activities that you have just started doing as a team, or that you've been investing in. Although they are not fully valuable yet, and probably take effort and discipline to do, they will become increasingly valuable as you keep doing them.
- **Maturity** represents the activities that are comfortable and valuable to you as a team. It doesn't take much effort or discipline to do them. It's become part of your rhythm as a Scrum Team.
- **Creative Destruction** represents the activities that have either lost their value to you as a team, or need to be reinvented in order to become useful again. Perhaps by doing it in a different way or from a different perspective. Or you want to stop doing them altogether.

All activities flow through the Ecocycle. But they can also get stuck. Activities that you know are important, but are never invested in, get stuck in the Poverty Trap. Activities that you keep doing, but aren't really adding any value any longer, are in the Rigidity Trap. By plotting all your activities across the Ecocycle, you can identify patterns that tell you something about where you are as a team. Look for the following patterns in particular:

- A healthy Ecocycle is balanced. There is innovation taking place, as evidenced by activities on the left of the model, and there are activities that are mature, as evidenced by items on the right. Furthermore, teams are continuously reinventing how to do things and become better, as represented in what is in Creative Destruction.
- Activities that are in the Rigidity Trap and Creative Destruction are prime candidates for reinvention or even removal. Start there before adding new activities, as this creates space for something new.

How To Prepare



Duration

This exercise takes between 90 and 120 minutes, depending on group size. You can pull steps 4 and 5 into separate sessions if you don't have that time.

Group Size

Ecocycle Planning can be done with one Scrum Team, but also with many at the same time. This allows you to see patterns across teams.

Intended Audience

This string is designed for Scrum Teams. We highly recommend that you include important stakeholders as well. The outcomes and the impediments you identify will affect and benefit them as well. Our experience is that Ecocycle Planning is a great way for them to see where they can contribute to a team that is delivering value to them.

Virtual Delivery

We've successfully used this exercise with virtual teams. It does require preparation and the right tools. In our work, we purposefully follow the principles of [Liberating Structures](#) and break down interactions into smaller groups to allow *everyone* to contribute – and not just the loud voices and know-it-alls. If you are working with a group beyond five participants, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#).

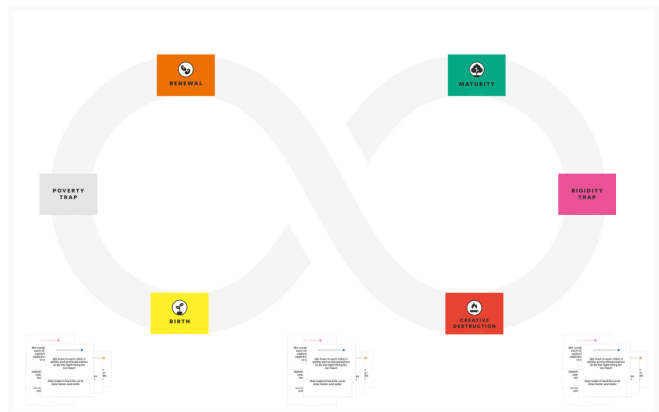
In in-person exercises, we put the cards on a flat surface. In a virtual session, you can use a virtual whiteboard like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#) to provide a similar experience. You can set up your canvas as shown in the screenshot. If you have multiple groups, copy the canvas a couple of times so that each group has its own canvas and sets of events and activities.

Material

- Create one shared, empty canvas for Ecocycle Planning (see screenshot) with a complete stack of Activity Cards for each group of four in your total group
- Ideally, prepare one empty canvas for Ecocycle Planning with a complete stack of Activity Cards for each individual in your collaboration tool. If that isn't possible, participants can draw their Ecocycles on paper.
- The set of activities we provide with the exercise work well. And you can easily add more cards or remove cards that are not relevant to your team.

Resources

- Whitepaper: [Scrum: A Framework to Reduce Risk And Deliver Value Sooner](#)
- Blog post: [Create focus with Ecocycle Planning](#)
- Blog post: [Help Development Teams Advance Their Technical Practices With Ecocycle Planning](#)
- Tool: [The Zombie Scrum Survey](#)



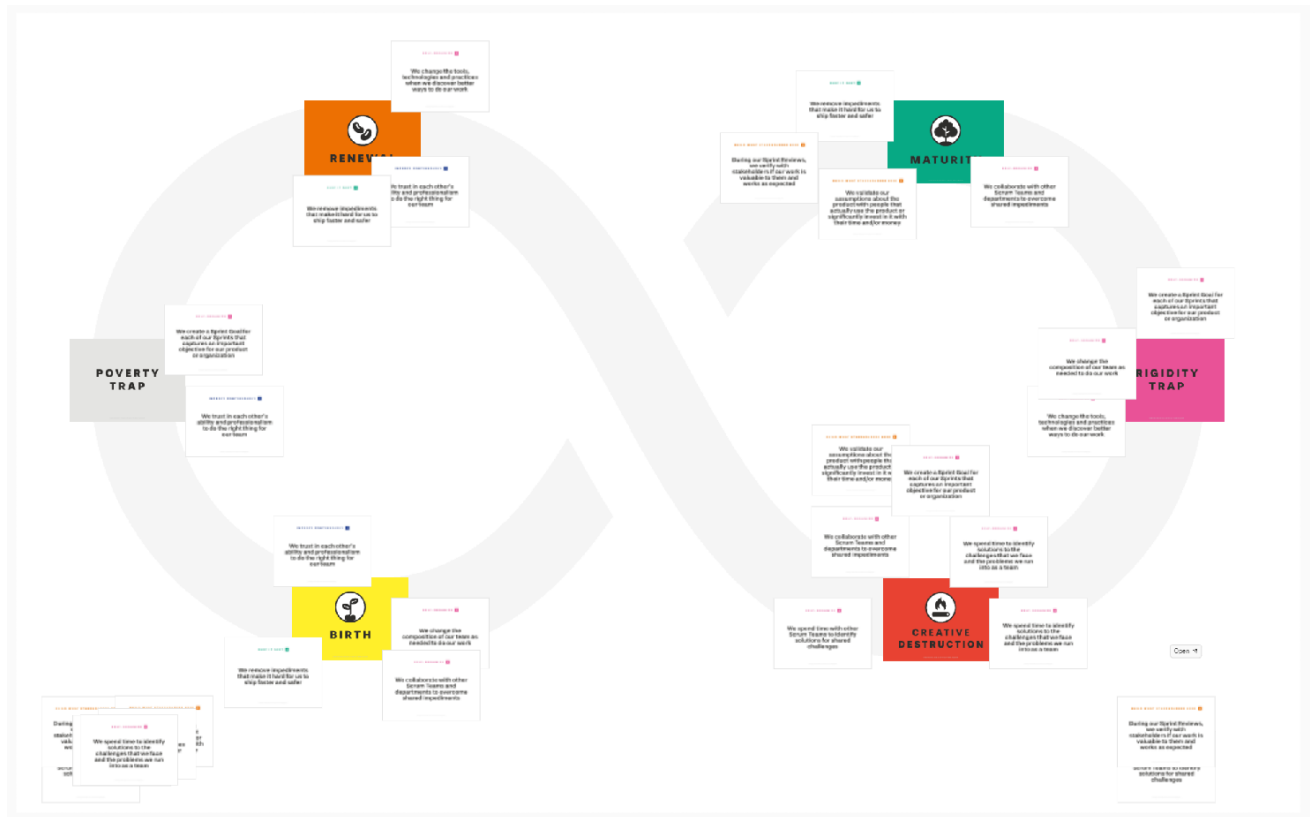
Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then introduce the purpose and start with the first step. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves or to wait for people to drop in.



Step 2: Diagnose The Status Quo



The first step with Ecocycle Planning is to create transparency around how your team is doing at the moment. From there, you can start the inspection and the adaptation.

Steps

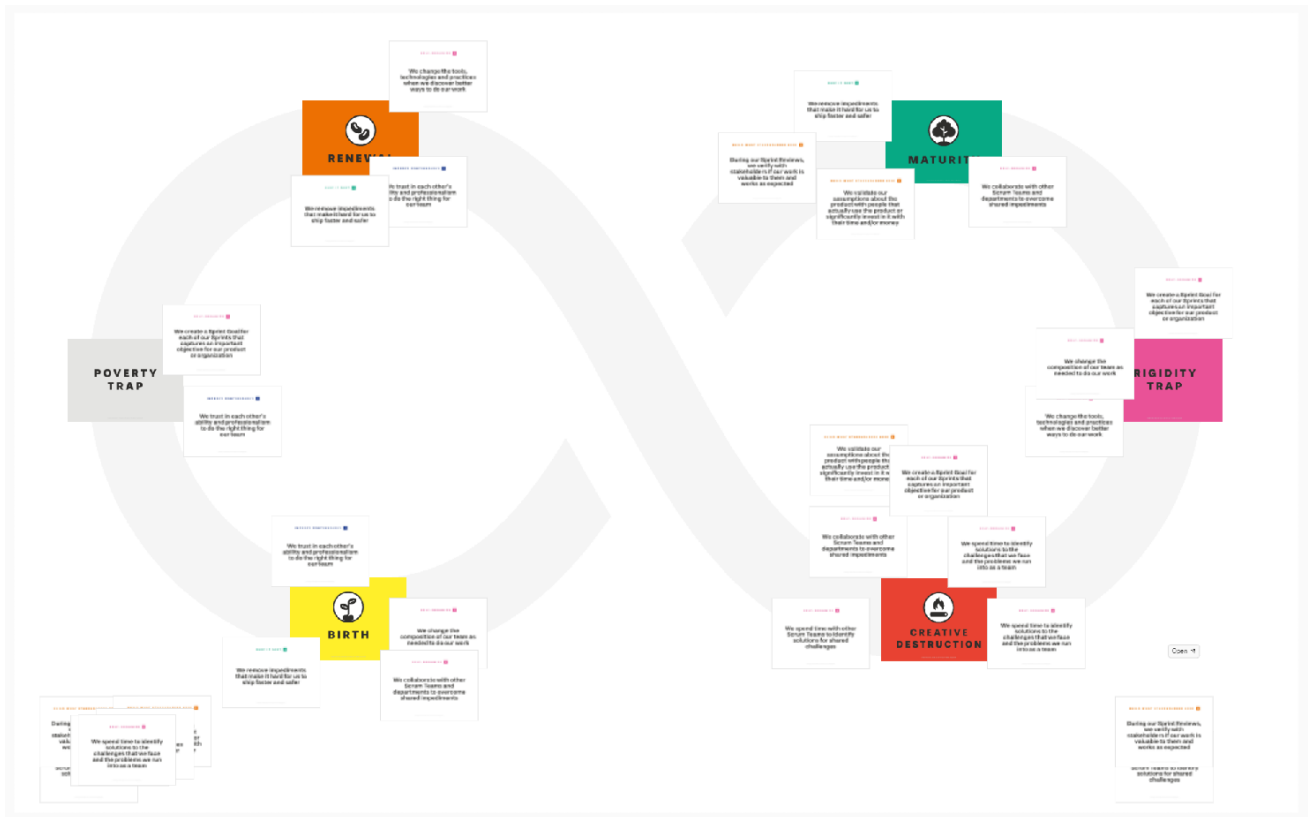
- 10 min** Introduce Ecocycle Planning. Explain the metaphor, the quadrants, and give some examples to help people understand it. It's okay if people don't get it right away; you often have to experience Ecocycle Planning several times to start seeing the possibilities. Introduce the Activity Cards and their four categories.
- 10 min** Invite people to fill in an Ecocycle Planning for their team. Either direct everyone to their individual empty canvas in your collaboration tool *or* ask people to draw an Ecocycle Planning on a piece of paper. Give them time to silently distribute the activities across their own Ecocycle based on where they think the activities are for the Scrum Team. In the meantime, prepare breakouts for groups of four.
- 3 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, introduce the shared and empty Ecocycle Canvas. Explain that people will be working together in the next steps to create a single Ecocycle Planning for their team that combines all their perspectives.
- 15 min** Invite people into small groups and into their own breakouts. Ask "In your small group, share your individual Ecocycles. Where do you see similarities and differences in how you placed activities for your team?". Ask the small groups to place activities in the shared Ecocycle Planning where they think they are as a small group. Encourage people not to over-think it.

Our Findings

- If people draw the Ecocycle Planning on a piece of paper, they can also write the numbers of the activities in the Ecocycle, together with a shorthand for the category (e.g. "Ship" or "SH").



Step 3: Inspect Together



In the previous step, you created transparency together around the status quo of your team. Where are they now? In this step, you work together to inspect what this means about your ability to work empirically.

Steps

- 4 min** Invite people to step back and take in the patterns in the shared Ecocycle you created in the previous step. Ask them to focus on the items for which there is consensus. Ask "What does the placement of the items say about our ability to ship fast and deliver value to our stakeholders? Where do you see connections between the items?". In the meantime, prepare breakouts for three rounds of different pairs.
- 15 min** Invite people into pairs and into their breakouts. Ask them to share the most salient patterns they notice (4 minutes). Repeat twice more in different pairs (8 minutes).
- 10 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, ask people to share the most salient patterns with the whole group. You can help draw out patterns by noticing where most cards of one color appear, whether or not the Ecocycle is balanced and which items appear in the traps. You may be at risk of Zombie Scrum when a lot of activities are on the left or in the traps.

Our Findings

- We purposefully use pairs, and not larger groups, to create safety for everyone to share their insights. Even in small groups, loud voices can drown out silent voices. By quickly rotating pairs, great insights and observations will spread through the group. If you really must do it with a larger group, use a [Conversation Cafe](#).
- Use "Creative Destruction" as the area where activities go that need to be creatively re-invented to be valuable again. An Ecocycle Planning with nothing in this area may be an indicator that double-loop learning – where existing structures are challenged – is limited in your team.



Step 4: Identify Improvements

In the previous step, you created transparency together around the status quo of your team. Then, you identified what that says about the ability of your team to work empirically. Now, in this final step, you help the team identify improvements.

Steps

1. **5 min** First individually and in silence, ask people to consider the following question for a few minutes: "Which activities do we need to creatively reinvent or expand in order to move forward as a Scrum Team?". In the meantime, prepare breakouts for pairs and – for the step after that – breakouts with two pairs each.
2. **15 min** Invite people into pairs and into their breakouts to share their ideas and build on them **5 min**. Then, invite the pairs into new breakouts with another pair to share their ideas and build on them **10 min**.
3. **10 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, ask every group to share two or three of their most promising ideas. Capture these potential improvements as input for your Product Backlog.
4. If you have the time and when the improvement ideas remain fairly abstract, you can use a Liberating Structure like "[Shift & Share](#)" to develop them further.

Our Findings

- You can also use [25/10 Crowd Sourcing](#) to quickly generate improvements ideas. David Heath created this [free virtual app](#) to do this online.
- When you are facing tough impediments, you can use Liberating Structures like [Discovery & Action Dialogue](#) and [Wise Crowds](#) to dig deeper.

Step 5: Personal Next Steps



We always close by asking people to write down a personal next step. This way, everyone can contribute to the solution in whatever way is possible for them. Many small steps together easily accumulate to large change.

Invitation

"What is your personal 15% Solution to contribute to the improvements we identified? What is something you can do that you do without permission from other or resources you don't have access to?"

Steps

1.  Ask everyone to silently generate a list of personal 15% Solutions.
2.  Form pairs and invite each pair into their own breakouts. In the breakouts, people take turns to share their 15% Solutions. We always encourage listeners to help their partner find ways to guarantee that they will actually do those things (e.g. make it smaller, simpler).

Our Findings

- It is tempting for people to complicate their 15% Solutions, which makes it unlikely they'll actually do them. You can encourage people by asking them "What is the thing you're going to do to work on that [original idea]?"
- You can make individual 15% Solutions transparent on your virtual whiteboard. But make sure that this is optional.



After The Exercise



With this exercise, you create transparency around where you are as a Scrum Team. We highly recommend that you revisit the Ecocycle of your team periodically, and create transparency around how your Scrum Team is developing.

Learn And Grow, Together

We know that you'll probably run into mind-bogglingly hard impediments. This is why we gladly invite you to join our growing [community of patrons](#). Here, you'll find many other Scrum practitioners who are eager to give and get help.

If you're stuck or have other questions about this exercise, reach out to us at info@theliberators.com. Let's learn and grow, together!

Help Us Improve This Exercise

We are eager to learn from your experience of this exercise. You probably discovered much about the flow of the exercise, the use of the invitations, and the impact on the group. What did it make possible for you or your team? What unexpected surprises did you run into? What would make it even better? [Help us learn from your experience by sharing it with us](#). It only takes a few minutes.

Share Your Outcomes

There is bound to be plenty of learning going on in your session. If you can, please share some of those results with the wider community. We always like to share a collage of pictures (with permission) or a short video. It is a nice way to inspire people to give the string a try as well!

Try Our Other Exercises



We offer many other exercises in our webshop at shop.theliberators.com. All are designed to create transparency within your team and to use that to inspect and adapt together.

For example, the [Definition of Done](#) exercise creates transparency around what happens when your team is unable to deliver "Done" increments every Sprint. [Management in Scrum](#) makes clear what management looks like in Scrum, and what makes Scrum Teams autonomous. You can also try The [Scrum Events & Activities](#) exercise, it creates transparency around the purpose of the various Scrum Events and how you're benefitting from that (or not).

Find many more at shop.theliberators.com.



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